



MAI statement

Statement from the multiplex association of India detailing how they are prepared to reopen theatres again. <https://digit.in/aug20-23>



PVR statement

The details of PVR's statement appealing filmmakers not to premiere movies directly on OTT platforms. <https://digit.in/aug20-24>

not be released in the theatrical chains. A statement by INOX was directed towards a single production house in particular and read, "The decision of the production house to deviate from the globally prevalent content window practice is alarming and disconcerting." INOX went ahead to refer to the production house as "fair-weather friends" in the statement. Kamal Gianchandani, CEO of PVR Cinemas said, "We are disappointed with some of our producers deciding to go straight to the streaming platform/s. We were hoping that the producers would accede to our request to hold back their film's release till cinemas reopen." The Multiplex Association of India also released a statement, asking for producers to honour existing agreements. "We urge all studios, producers, artistes and other content creators to kindly respect the exclusive theatrical window which has been a time-tested industry practice agreed to by all stakeholders, not just in India, but even globally for several decades."

The Producer's Guild of India responded to these statements with one of their own. In brief, the statement outlined the various costs being borne by the producers, including that of accumulating interest on the funded films and as well lack of insurance coverage for sunk costs studio rentals and sets. The guild called for the exhibitors to not take an adversarial stance in the time of crisis and pointed out that if and when the theatres do open anyway, they are likely to be staggered across the country and not fully occupied anyway because of social distancing norms. The statement read, "it is disappointing to see abrasive and unconstructive messaging from some of our colleagues in the exhibition sector. Statements that call for "retributive measures" against producers who decide to take their movies direct to OTT platforms – especially at a time when cinemas are unfortunately closed for the foreseeable future – do not lend themselves to a constructive

or collaborative dialogue on the way forward for the industry."

Meanwhile, both telecom service providers and OTT platforms are themselves struggling to meet the sudden surge in demand. In April, The Cellular Operators Association of India wrote to the OTT providers asking for them to voluntarily restrict streaming to SD resolution in their services. "We believe that during this critical time, it is absolutely essential for the streaming platforms to cooperate with TSPs to manage traffic distribution patterns which are likely to strain network infrastructure at a time when it is needed for vari-



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Cinema workers gearing up for the eventual reopening of theatres

ous critical requirements," the letter said. Within a week, all the major streaming services complied with the request, with Facebook and Google joining in as well.

THE WAY BACK

Meanwhile exhibitors are doing everything they can to make sure that the theatres are at least opened, and in these empty theatre halls, preparations are already underway for the eventual return of movie goers. The entire process will be reworked, with the entry screening being automated instead of a pat down. The workers will not manually handle the baggage, and instead this will be a self service as well. The checking of tickets is expected to be entirely through the use of barcode scanners, without the physical copies passed on between the workers and the viewers.

In fact, theatre chains may even do away with paper tickets permanently. Of course, there will be infrared temperature scanners, as well as hand sanitisers at various points, similar to the systems in place in supermarkets now. Instead of packed theatre halls, expect a requirement for an audience peppered with mandatory empty seats. Theatres are expected to be filled only up to 60 percent of their full capacity. Digital booking of seats is expected to help in managing this requirement. The intervals are expected to become longer to allow everyone to get their food and bio breaks while at the same time following social distancing norms. In all the places within the theatre, the one metre distance is expected to be followed, which means the demarkations on the ground for the food stalls and the restrooms as well. Forget paper menus at the food counter and expect at least some chains cashing in by selling immunity boosting drinks. The popcorn staple is not going to go away, but maybe there will be automatic vending machines. At the end of the screening, expect an orderly and row wise exit procedure.

Regular screenings would also require regular sanitising of the seats and other touch points such as railings of stairs. Each screening would be followed by a deeper clean of the auditorium than is usually done, along with disinfection and fumigation, so expect wider gaps between screenings, and fewer screenings per day.

The Multiplex Association of India has appealed to the Government to open up the theatres faster, and have expressed their disappointment at a lack of easing restrictions for moviegoers during the unlock phases. As the cinemagoers are all revenue paying customers as against unorganised locations such as supermarkets, the theatre owners argue that they are better equipped to ensure social distancing norms through the pandemic. In any case, forget about the raucous crowds at packed Gaiety Galaxy following a Salman Khan release. 